

TO PARENTS FROM PARENTS



MANAGING DEVELOPMENTAL ISSUES

Children born with congenital heart defects (CHDs) who need surgery or medical intervention often have what are called “neurodevelopmental” issues. This term can be scary for parents, but it simply means that your child may not meet developmental milestones at the same time as expected for children their age and may be more likely to have autism spectrum disorders. Getting help from specialists can make a big difference for you and your child. Here are some tips from parents too:



EDUCATE YOURSELF

It is always helpful to understand your child’s heart condition and some of the issues that can go along with it like neurodevelopmental issues. When you educate yourself, you are better able to recognize when there is a problem or delay, and you can get the help and support you and your child need. You are also able to make decisions that can help your child have a better chance at success.



GET YOUR CHILD SCREENED

Your child’s cardiologist should be familiar with recommended screening for neurodevelopmental issues and at what ages your child should be screened. The American Heart Association has screening guidelines that you can review. As of 2022, screening is recommended at 9, 18 and 30 months and again before starting school at about age 4. These guidelines may be updated. If your child has a genetic condition or signs of more severe developmental issues, additional screenings may be needed.



KNOW YOUR TEAM

It’s important to understand what specialists work with neurodevelopmental issues and how to get support and services your child needs. Sometimes, your child’s pediatrician and cardiologist can help connect you with early intervention services for your child like physical therapy, occupational therapy, speech therapy, and feeding therapy. In some areas, there are developmental pediatricians and/or neurodevelopmental programs for children born with CHD. Don’t be afraid to contact a program in another location if there isn’t one near you.



GET SUPPORT

Dealing with developmental, learning and behavioral issues can be difficult and emotionally challenging for parents. It can help to put a support system in place. Your child’s health care team can be helpful in providing support and recommending support resources. You may have resources in your local area or state. Also, there are support groups for parents who have been through similar experiences, and they can provide support from someone who has been there.



AVOID COMPARING AND CELEBRATE SUCCESSES

When your child isn’t meeting milestones at the same time as other children or has some behavioral issues, it can be hard not to feel frustrated and discouraged. Avoid comparing your child to other children and focus on your child’s progress instead. With treatment, your child is likely to progress. It can be helpful to keep a journal and look back and see how far your child has come. Be sure to celebrate even the small wins along the way.

It can be hard to deal with developmental issues and CHD at the same time. You can find more information and helpful tips on dealing with developmental issues at www.mendedlittlehearts.org.